

Second chance: On the U.S. and the Iran nuclear deal

Iran has reason to **be wary of** Trump's **dialogue** proposal

It was Donald Trump who **sabotaged** the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), better known as the Iran nuclear deal. **When Mr. Trump**, in his first term as President (2017-21), **unilaterally withdrew** the U.S. from the agreement in May 2018, Iran was fully **compliant** with the **terms**. Mr. Trump then adopted his 'maximum pressure' policy aimed at forcing Iran to **renegotiate** the deal — a move which Tehran **rebuffed**. Last week, Mr. Trump said he had sent a letter to Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, asking him to reopen dialogue or risk military action. While the letter's details are still private, it took only two days for the Iranian leader to reject the **outreach**. Mr. Khamenei said "some **bullying** governments" **insist on** talks not to **resolve** the issue but to **impose** their deals. Iran's reaction is not **entirely** surprising. In 2013, Tehran had taken Barack Obama's **overtures** quite seriously. Mr. Khamenei had fully **backed** the Hassan Rouhani presidency's **bid** to negotiate with **the West**. And they had reached a result-oriented agreement which cut Iran's path towards nuclear weapons in return for the **lifting** of international **sanctions**. Now, when **the American leader** who **demolished** the functional agreement **reaches out** to them, the Iranians are **sceptical** for obvious reasons. Yet, there is a **compelling** argument to retake the path of diplomacy.

In 2018, when Mr. Trump imposed maximum pressure, Iran responded with maximum **resistance**. This **mutual brinkmanship** **escalated** regional tensions — Saudi Arabian oil **facilities** came under attack, Iran **shot down** an American drone, the U.S. **assassinated** Gen. Qassem Soleimani and Tehran **retaliated** with a missile **strike** on an American base in Iraq. While Mr. Trump's White House **exit** in 2021 **ushered in** the hope that the nuclear deal could be revived under the Biden administration, it did not happen. Over the four years, the region has seen dramatic **developments**. Today's Iran is weaker than what it was in 2020. Israel's war against Hamas and Hezbollah has weakened the '**Axis of Resistance**'. Last year saw Israel and Iran exchange attacks. The **fall** of Syria's Assad **regime**, Tehran's only state **ally** in West Asia, in December 2024, **shrank** Iran's strategic depth in a **hostile** region. The country is also in deep economic pain, and the Israelis seem willing to take greater military risks, **provided** they have American **backing**. **Amid** challenges, Iran **reportedly possesses** enough high-grade fuel to produce weapons — Mr. Trump has **acknowledged** this with his 'we are reaching a critical point'. The U.S. wants to resolve the nuclear problem and Iran wants **lasting** economic and diplomatic **reprieves**. **Beneath** the **hostility**, there is a strategic possibility to resume **dialogue**. There is no harm in the Iranians giving it a second chance.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Reprieve** (noun) – Pardon, amnesty, acquittal, absolution, exculpation, exoneration दण्डविराम
- **Beneath** (preposition) – Under, below, नीचे
- **Hostility** (noun) – Aggression, anger, unfriendliness, resentment, शत्रुता

Vocabulary

1. (be) **wary** (of) (adjective) – Cautious, Careful, Suspicious, Alert, Hesitant सतर्क
2. **Dialogue** (noun) – Conversation, Discussion, Talk, Negotiation, Exchange संवाद
3. **Sabotage** (verb) – Undermine, Disrupt, Damage, Destroy, Wreck नाकाम करना
4. **Unilaterally** (adverb) – Independently, Solely, Exclusively, Alone, Single-handedly एकतरफा
5. **Compliant** (with) (adjective) – Obedient, Conforming, Submissive, Agreeable, Cooperative अनुपालन करने वाला
6. **Terms** (noun) – Condition, stipulation, provision, requisite शर्त
7. **Renegotiate** (verb) – Revisit, Revise, Reassess, Reconsider, Reopen पुनः बातचीत करना
8. **Rebuff** (verb) – Reject, Refuse, Decline, Snub, Dismiss ठुकराना
9. **Outreach** (noun) – Engagement, Communication, Interaction, Connection, Involvement संपर्क
10. **Bully** (verb) – Intimidate, Harass, Dominate, Oppress, Threaten भयभीत करना
11. **Insist** (on) (verb) – Demand, Persist, Urge, Maintain, Assert जोर देना
12. **Resolve** (verb) – Solve, Settle, Fix, Address, Determine हल करना
13. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, Apply, Levy, Introduce, Inflict थोपना
14. **Entirely** (adverb) – Completely, Totally, Fully, Wholly, Absolutely पूरी तरह
15. **Overture** (noun) – Proposal, Offer, Approach, Initiative, Suggestion प्रस्ताव
16. **Back** (verb) – Support, Endorse, Advocate, Promote, Assist समर्थन करना
17. **Bid** (noun) – Attempt, Effort, Try, Proposal, Offer प्रयास
18. **The West** (noun) – Western countries, Europe, America, Occident, Western world पश्चिमी देश
19. **Lift** (verb) – Remove, Revoke, Cancel, Withdraw, Suspend हटाना
20. **Sanction** (noun) – Penalty, Punishment, Restriction, Embargo, Ban प्रतिबंध
21. **Demolish** (verb) – Destroy, Ruin, Wreck, Dismantle, Raze तोड़ना
22. **Reach out** (phrasal verb) – Contact, Approach, Communicate, Connect, Extend संपर्क करना

23. **Sceptical** (adjective) – Doubtful, Suspicious, Distrustful, Unconvinced, Hesitant संदेही
24. **Compelling** (adjective) – Convincing, Persuasive, Strong, Powerful, Forceful प्रभावशाली
25. **Resistance** (noun) – Opposition, Defiance, Rebellion, Struggle, Pushback प्रतिरोध
26. **Mutual** (adjective) – Reciprocal, Shared, Common, Joint, Bilateral आपसी
27. **Brinkmanship** (noun) – the art or practice of pursuing a dangerous policy to the limits of safety before stopping, especially in politics. तनाव
28. **Escalate** (verb) – Intensify, Increase, Heighten, Amplify, Aggravate बढ़ाना
29. **Facilities** (noun) – a service, building, piece of equipment, etc. that makes it possible to do something.
30. **Shoot down** (phrasal verb) – Destroy, Bring down, Hit, Strike, Attack गिराना
31. **Assassinated** (adjective) – Murdered, Killed, Executed, Eliminated, Slain हत्या किया हुआ
32. **Retaliate** (verb) – Revenge, Counterattack, Strike back, Respond, Avenge प्रतिशोध लेना
33. **Strike** (noun) – Attack, Assault, Hit, Blow, Raid हमला
34. **Usher in** (phrasal verb) – Introduce, Begin, Initiate, Launch, Herald शुरूआत करना
35. **Development** (noun) – Event, happening, occurrence, change, incident, घटनाक्रम
36. **Axis of Resistance** (noun) – An informal coalition of Iranian-supported militias and political organizations across the Middle East.
37. **Regime** (noun) – Government, Administration, Rule, Authority, Leadership शासन
38. **Ally** (noun) – Partner, Supporter, Associate, Collaborator, Friend सहयोगी
39. **Shrink** (verb) – Reduce, Decrease, Diminish, Contract, Decline कम करना
40. **Hostile** (adjective) – Unfriendly, Aggressive, Antagonistic, Opposing, Adverse शत्रुतापूर्ण
41. **Provided** (conjunction) – If, Assuming, Given, On condition that, Supposing बशर्ते
42. **Backing** (noun) – Support, Assistance, Endorsement, Funding, Sponsorship समर्थन
43. **Amid** (preposition) – Among, In the middle of, Surrounded by, During, Within के बीच
44. **Reportedly** (adverb) – Allegedly, Supposedly, Apparently, Purportedly, Ostensibly कथित तौर पर

45. **Possess** (verb) – Own, Have, Hold, Control,
Acquire रखना

47. **Lasting** (adjective) – Enduring, Permanent,
Long-term, Persistent, Sustained स्थायी

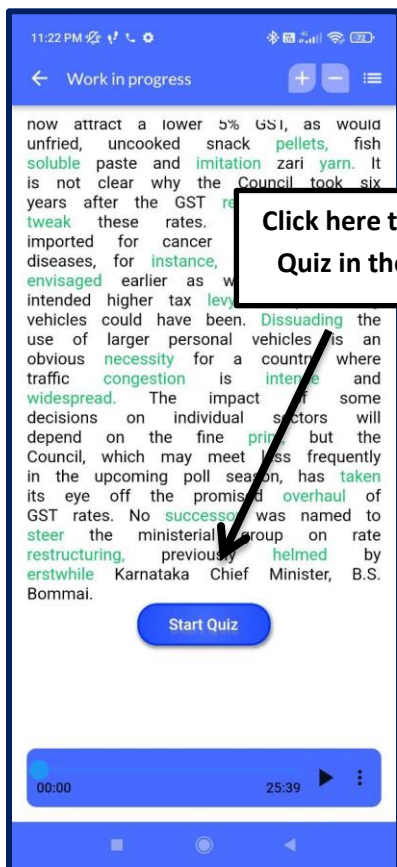
46. **Acknowledge** (verb) – Admit, Recognize,
Accept, Concede, Grant स्वीकार करना

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Summary of the Editorial

1. **Trump's Role in JCPOA Sabotage:** Donald Trump unilaterally withdrew the U.S. from the Iran nuclear deal (JCPOA) in May 2018, despite Iran being fully compliant at the time.
2. **'Maximum Pressure' Policy:** After withdrawing, Mr. Trump adopted a hardline strategy aimed at forcing Tehran to renegotiate the agreement, which Iran firmly rejected.
3. **Recent Letter to Khamenei:** Mr. Trump claims to have sent a new letter to Iran's Supreme Leader, threatening military action if dialogue is not reopened.
4. **Immediate Iranian Rejection:** Ayatollah Ali Khamenei dismissed the overture, referring to "bullying governments" trying to impose their own terms under the guise of talks.
5. **Historical Openness:** Iran had previously shown willingness to engage with the U.S. under President Obama, culminating in the successful 2015 agreement.
6. **Functional Deal Dismantled:** That earlier JCPOA had imposed limits on Iran's nuclear program in exchange for economic relief — until Mr. Trump's withdrawal ended the arrangement.
7. **Mutual Brinkmanship:** Post-2018, tensions surged: Iranian-backed attacks on Saudi facilities, the downing of a U.S. drone, and the U.S. assassination of Gen. Soleimani, followed by Iranian reprisals.
8. **Hope under Biden Unfulfilled:** There were expectations of a revived deal when Joe Biden took office in 2021, but it has yet to materialize.
9. **Changing Regional Context:** The fall of the Assad regime in Syria in December 2024 weakened Iran's only major state ally in the region. This shrinkage of Tehran's strategic depth has affected its regional standing.
10. **Israel vs. 'Axis of Resistance':** Israel's recent confrontations with Hamas and Hezbollah have disrupted Iran's broader regional network and created military pressure on Tehran.
11. **Iran's Economic Struggles:** Economic hardship, partly due to sanctions, has weakened Iran, making a negotiated deal potentially more attractive.
12. **Potential Weapons-Grade Fuel:** Despite challenges, Iran is believed to have enough enriched uranium to be near weapons capability, which concerns the U.S. and Israel.
13. **Trump's Acknowledgment:** He admits a "critical point" has been reached regarding Iran's nuclear progress, underscoring the urgency of addressing the standoff.
14. **Mutual Interests:** While the U.S. wants to curb Iran's nuclear ambitions, Iran seeks credible economic and diplomatic relief — a foundation for potential talks.
15. **Editorial Call for Diplomacy:** Despite past setbacks and current mistrust, the editorial argues that resuming dialogue offers a pragmatic path forward for both sides.

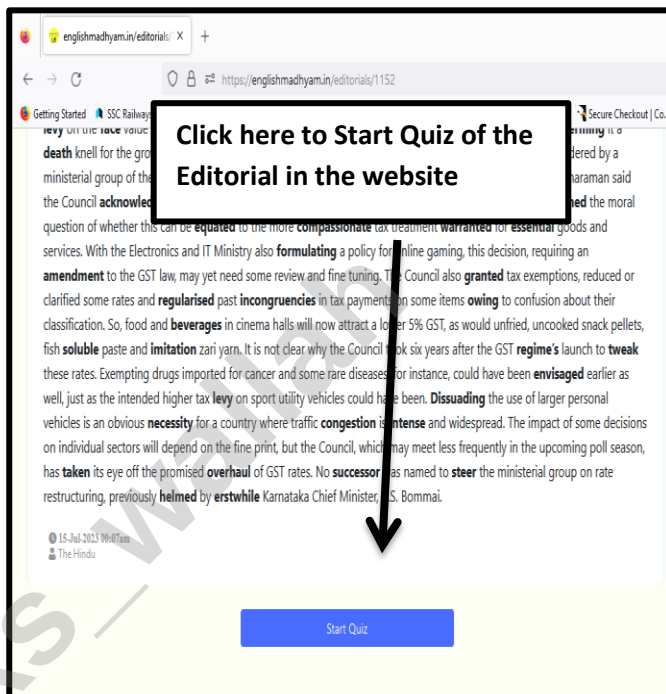
Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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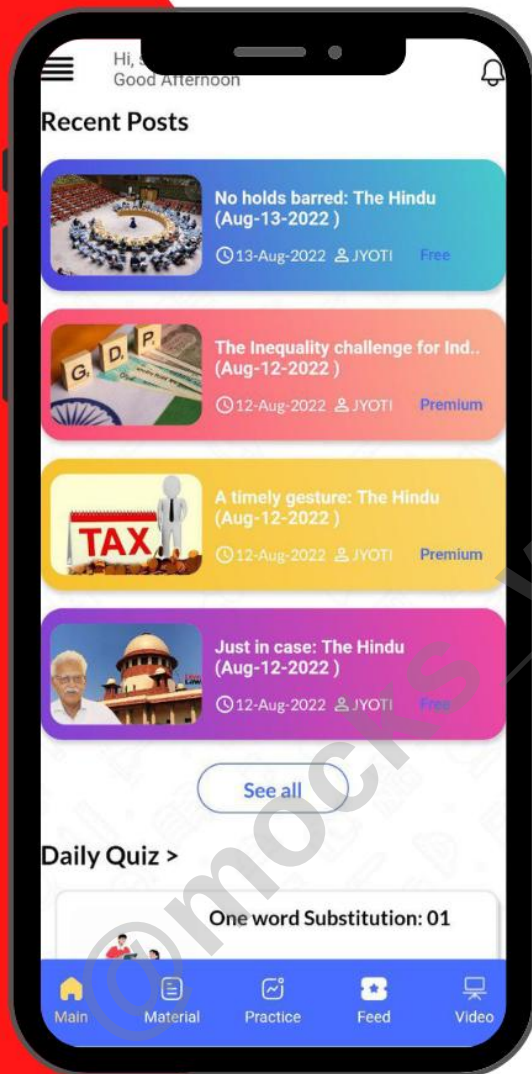
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